



Food

Sweet, sticky and sold out everywhere: why is there such a craze for Dubai chocolate?

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The creamy pistachio bar is all over TikTok, but good luck trying to find it in shops. Even so, when she began selling it through her online shop, it wasn't an instant success. So she tried sending bars to local influencers. One of them was Maria Vehera, who posts ecstatic videos of herself trying delicious new treats in her car. The [video of her trying Dubai chocolate](#) went viral in December 2023 and has now had more than 122m views. In an interview with the New York Times this year, Hamouda said her company received more than 30,000 orders after Vehera's video went up.

<https://www.tiktok.com/@mariavehera257/video/7313986849104481538>

Can “virality” be “engineered”

	1) A	2) B.	3) C.	4) D
I. Viewing				
Humor	X	X	X	X
Celebrities + entertainment	X		X	X
Social Media + interaction		X		X
II. Sharing				
Story format	X			X
III. Website visitation				
Web component		X		X
IV. Brand consistency	X			X
Total Score	4	3	2	6

Comparing TV ads and Influencer effects: CPM Calculation

TV Ad Type	CPM (Cost per 1,000 viewers)
National Broadcast TV (<i>Primetime</i>)	\$20–\$50
National Cable TV (<i>Primetime</i>)	\$10–\$30
Local Broadcast TV	\$5–\$30
Streaming TV/OTT	\$25–\$60 (<i>targeted</i>)
Live Sports (excluding Super Bowl)	\$30–\$60
Super Bowl Ads	\$55–\$65 (<i>Premium CPM</i>)

Influencer Pricing Breakdown (Average benchmarks):

- **Instagram:** Typically around \$5,000–\$20,000 per million followers
- **TikTok:** Around \$4,000–\$15,000 per million followers
- **YouTube:** Around \$5,000–\$25,000 per million subscribers
- **Twitter/X:** Generally lower pricing, around \$2,500–\$10,000 per million followers.
- **Facebook:** Approximately \$3,000–\$10,000 per million followers

So for a thousand views, influencers on Instagram cost between \$5 and \$20

Engagement metrics

	Expected Engagement (in seconds)	
Action taken	Television	Online (Viral) Ads
View	50% * 30 seconds	71% * 30 seconds
+ visit brand's website	?	71% * 16% * 120 seconds
+ forward to someone	~0%	71% * 4% * 30 seconds
= Total Engagement Time	15 seconds + ?	36 seconds
CPM / second	\$30/15s = \$2	\$10/36s = \$0.28

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The main field experiment was conducted from June to August 2018 in Zaoyang, Hubei and involved 34 villages and 702 farmers (one farmer per household).

Social Media, Influencers, and Adoption of an Eco-Friendly Product: Field Experiment Evidence from Rural China

Wanqing Zhang, Pradeep K. Chintagunta, and Manohar U. Kalwani

Abstract

Can low-cost marketing tools that are used to enhance business performance also contribute to creating a better world? The authors investigate the role of online social media tools in alleviating customer (farmer) uncertainty and promoting the adoption of a new eco-friendly pesticide in rural China via a randomized controlled field experiment. The key finding is that even for a new product such as a pesticide, a low-cost social media support platform can effectively promote adoption. A combination of information from peers and from the firm on the platform facilitates learning about product features and alleviates uncertainty associated with product quality and appropriate product usage. Nevertheless, at the trial stage of the funnel, the platform underperforms the firm's customized one-on-one support because available information does not resolve uncertainty in supplier credibility and product authenticity. Having an influencer on the platform, albeit not an expert on this product, vouching for its credibility helps resolve this funnel-holdup problem. From a theoretical perspective, this paper provides suggestive evidence for referent influence and credibility signaling on social media platforms and consequences for new product trial. The authors also provide direct empirical evidence on how information facilitates learning, a phenomenon typically assumed to be present in studies estimating learning models.